line-up. Shaun Pollock, Makhaya Ntini, Charl Langeveldt, Andrew Hall and the ever-gutsy and combative André Nel are our bowlers.

The tournament is going to be a marathon rather than a sprint, with the pool phase being followed by a Super Eight phase followed by semi-finals and the final. The drawn-out format appears to suit the needs of television rather than the game, providing endless broadcast hours but lacking focus and intensity.

We are based at Basseterre on the beautiful island of St Kitts, and start our campaign with emphatic victories over the Netherlands and Scotland. The tragic and untimely death of Bob Woolmer, who was coaching Pakistan and had just seen his team lose to Ireland, casts a shadow over the World Cup but the cricket continues and we lose to Australia by 83 runs in our third match, although both teams have already qualified for the Super Eights.

More than three weeks into the trip, the cricket is finally becoming meaningful and we squeak home against Sri Lanka, reaching a target of 210 with one wicket and 10 balls to spare. I am dismissed for nought, on my way to setting a new record of four ducks in a World Cup, and yet I would still manage to average over 40 in the tournament. For me, the 2007 World Cup would be a story of either zero or hero, with very little in between.

We defeat Ireland next but then lose to Bangladesh in Guyana and suddenly find ourselves under pressure when we play the hosts West Indies in Grenada. Batting first, at 36 for the loss of Graeme after 10 overs, we are getting ourselves into a tight corner, but Jacques Kallis and I steady the innings and add 170 runs in 29 overs.

My hamstrings are sore and I start to cramp repeatedly. As running becomes more and more painful, I resort to hitting boundaries and eventually finish with 146 from 130 balls. Herschelle and Bouch continue to attack and, when it really counts, we post an imposing total of 356 for